MSc/PGCert Project Briefing
The Proposal

Prof George Magoulas
g.magoulas@bbk.ac.uk

Part2

Outline

- What is a Project proposal?
- How to start?
- Key sections and content
- Marking criteria
- Using and referring to existing material/sources and assessment offences
- Final piece of advice
- The next briefing

What is a project proposal?

- A proposal is a general discussion about your project work: What is the aim of your work and how do you plan to implement it?
  - The submission takes the form of a report that you submit on Moodle
- The Project proposal (20%), e.g. 60*0.2= 12 credits → almost like a typical MSc module; 30*0.2= 6 credits-> half of a PGCert module
- Approximately 2000-**3000(max)** words for MSc; 1000-**1500(max)** words for PGCert
  - with an allowance of up to 20 percent above the max limit. Word count does not include References or Appendices. Any work exceeding the specified limits will incur a penalty of 10 marks under the Presentation criterion.
- Your own work, except where explicitly stated in your submission
- Examples of proposals are on the MSc project website on Moodle and in the college library.
- A Word template is provided in the “Key Information” tile on Moodle.

What is a project proposal?

- A proposal is a general discussion [illegible] t work: What is the aim of your work and how [illegible] plan [illegible]
  - For most MSc/PGC [illegible] report that [illegible]
  - For MAS s [illegible] you submit via Moodle and th [illegible] sor.
- The Pro [illegible] edits → almost like a typical m [illegible] a PG [illegible] module
- Approximatel [illegible] 000-1 [illegible] words for PGCert
- Your own work, exce [illegible] e [illegible] citly stated in your submission
- Examples of reports [illegible] on the project pages on Moodle and in the college library.

On 8 May 2026

you won't be able to submit a Proposal unless you have an approved project kernel (a grade of 100/100). Please refer to the "Kernel Submission" tile.

Some ideas on how to start?

- what is your project about and why is this interesting and appropriate for MSc/PGCert project?
- did you do any literature analysis, and if so, what is the most common problems identified in the literature?
- what is the right method(s) or approach for implementing the project?
- do you plan to use any data, and if so, what is this data about and where will you find it?
- what is your preferred project development plan and programming language or software packages and why?

example

Let's say that you want to create your own GitHub repository, named *DevSphere*

example

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Project title: **AI-enhanced DevSphere- A Scalable Alternative to Traditional Version Control Systems**

Building your own GitHub-like platform is an ambitious project and you may need to narrow it down.

example

did you do any literature analysis, and if so, what is the most common problems identified in the literature?

- the development of platforms like GitHub was strongly influenced by foundational academic research in areas such as version control, collaborative software engineering, distributed computing, and human-computer interaction
- GitHub's structure has been studied in relation to citation impact, collaboration patterns, and research reproducibility, leading to new ideas for transparency, knowledge sharing, and project maintenance
- Collaborative coding environments and real-time tools now draw from research on distributed cognition, live collaboration technologies, and education, integrating lessons from studies like those on Google Docs and remote teamwork
- Major GitHub Alternatives: GitLab, Bitbucket etc
- Analyse platforms, identify core functions, collaboration features, user perceptions, factors affecting adoption etc.

- what is the right method(s) or approach for implementing the project?
  - Software engineering methods- find suitable and justify choice
  - Produce requirements based on previous analysis (analysis of literature and existing platforms can help you deriving your own requirement)

Key sections and content

- **Cover/title page:** It is mandatory for your proposal to have a cover/title page with the following details. Title of Project; Title of your Programme of Study; Your name; School of Computing and Mathematical Sciences, Birkbeck, University of London; Word count.

Indicative structure- discuss with your supervisor what is best for your own project

- **Introduction**
- **Aims and Objectives**
- **Description of the problem and relevant work**
- **Methodology and methods** (and tools/technologies used to implement each method)
- **Organise and plan the project-** the workplan
- *Ethics, risks and mitigation strategies*

Aims and objectives

- Aims are usually broad and cover the main reasons why the project is important in terms of answering a particular need, or to fulfil a specific goal.
- In the section Aims and Objectives, start with a short paragraph describing the main aims of your project.
- Provide a list of objectives. These are the steps that lead to achieving your aim. No more that 6 objectives usually in a student project. You can also think of the objectives as the key stages of the project. Formulating these will enable you to plan the work, but also to provide a series of requirements and goals with which you will be able to evaluate the success of your project as part of the Critical Evaluation for the final project report
- Do aims and objectives sound achievable (feasible), or are they too complex given the timeframe?

Example-1

- If you are creating a piece of **software** about a potential client, then this part might be straightforward since your aim will largely be influenced by the user requirements (but do not just list a set of requirements and consider those as the Aim)
- The fact that you have to write various scripts, programs, integrate tools etc does not mean that these are objectives of your project. For example, all these could be considered as tasks that you have to do in order to meet the project Implementation objective. Another example of objective for software projects is to extract Requirements and translate these requirements into functionalities/features of your system. Design and Testing are usually considered as objective.

Example-2

- If your project is **data-driven**, let's say about predictive analytics, then perhaps your aim is to investigate the potential of neural network architectures to model data and produce useful outputs to inform an investment strategy.
- Normally objectives should include steps like:
  - Critically review existing approaches;
  - Formulate the problem and identify data and features to be used, as well as an appropriate experimental and evaluation framework;
  - Identify appropriate neural architectures and train these to produce outputs that could be used to inform an investment strategy; test proposed models in real-world conditions and against appropriate benchmarks;
  - Identify the most appropriate modelling architecture and further optimise the model by carrying out a study of the importance of model parameters and features used.

Description of the problem and relevant work

- Background research will enable you to provide a clear description and context for your project. Someone may have done what you are proposing, in which case, you need to argue why your solution improves, offers additional insights or builds upon an existing solution. The good news is that you do not have to propose something original!
- Summarise each source in terms of its contribution, impact, or methods: What did they do? Why was it important and worth doing? Identify common themes. Who will benefit from the research or software application.
- How does your project fit in? Does it extend or improve on previous work in your area of interest?

Methodology and methods

- Describe the **overall project methodology** and the methods that will be used to meet the objectives of the project/the specifications. You can also provide a diagram that illustrate your approach/data pipeline.
- For each objective you can provide methodology, methods and tools that you will use, and organise this part accordingly.
- Also discuss the difference between an evaluation with respect to how your software performs, versus a critical evaluation where you reflect on your aims and objectives and to what degree they satisfied.
- If there are experiments (e.g. DS projects), explain why certain experiments will be carried out but not others? What are the important parameters in the simulation and how might they affect the results?
- How do you plan to implement it? E.g. if you are using machine learning, you will require a model (explain the structure of the neural network) and training data (how big is it, is it balanced), if you are developing a mobile app, then perhaps there is a particular framework you need to support the OS of your choice (Apple or Android).

example

- **For the software project (Example-1)**, assuming that you have four objectives, i.e. Requirements specification, System/Software Design, Implementation, and Testing/Evaluation, you can organise the Methods section per objective.
- -Requirements: explain what methods you will use to gather requirements, critically evaluate existing approaches etc.; prioritise requirements
- - Design: how will this be done? What methods, use cases, UML? Will you use any tools? How will you make sure that your design meet the requirements?
- - Implementation: how it will be done; schematic of software architecture, components etc What tools, platforms, libraries will you use/reuse?
- - Testing: what methods, data/test cases etc. How will you evaluate- any metrics?
- - Fine tuning or optimisation: sometimes this is optional but there are projects which is necessary to include it.

Organise and plan the project

- You have to convince the marker and the supervisor that you are able to manage your time and juggle two separate concerns: software artefacts (software app, ML models) and final report.
- Develop a realistic workplan for the project.
- Markers:
  - Are looking at how you articulate and present your plan for the coming development work.
  - Want to understand whether you are able to produce a good plan that is feasible and achievable to succeed in completing your project
  - Are looking for evidence that you are able to organise project resources, risks, and challenges. You need to demonstrate knowledge of common strategies used to identify risks and manage them.

example

Provide a chart or table that shows what are the Workpackages. You can create a Gantt chart reflecting the main stages of development of your project. This should detail coherent phases of development

- WP: it helps to consider the objectives, mentioned in above examples, as workpackages; describe what tasks each WP contains.
- Tasks/activities within a WP: go back to Objectives and Methods sections. Look for any references to activities or tasks related to these objectives or particular Methods. Provide a time estimate for the duration of each task/activity, e.g.
  - Gathering data and/or resources.
  - Prototyping and final development phases for each of the main components of your system.
  - Testing and evaluation. Testing includes different types of tests, writing test cases etc.

example

- Meetings with supervisor, drafting chapters of the report etc are not included in the project Workplan, unless you introduce a Management workpackage, which includes meetings, deliverables writing, milestones etc.
- For a **software project**, do not forget to consider the process of testing your software, producing results, and evaluating the outputs of your project for write up in your final report.
- For a **data-driven project**, do not forget that it takes time to run experiments or simulations and that relevant code should be written or reused.

Ethics, risks and mitigation strategies

With respect to **Ethics**, discuss with your supervisor whether your project has ethical implications.

- Most of the time, this is routine and you do not have to submit an Ethics form.
- If you collect your own data using interviews, observations, survey, questionnaires etc, then you have to fill in an “Ethical Review Form” (available on the project Moodle page- KEY INFORMATION tile) and include it in the Project proposal.

Ethical approval

Fill in the Ethical Review Form (available on the KEY INFORMATION tile on Moodle) and include it in the Project proposal. **However, this is not ethical approval.**

- **Remember:**
  - If you are using data (e.g. user data, patient data etc) collected by others, you do not need ethical approval but in your proposal and report you could refer to the ethical approval obtained by these researchers. You should be able to find relevant information on the data repository that you use, or the article that uses this dataset.
  - In general, if you collect your own data from human participants (e.g. user study, questionnaires, online survey, patient records etc), then you have to obtain ethical approval for your project.

- **If you're uncertain about the need for ethical approval for your project, your supervisor is the one to consult for guidance.**
- **To get ethical approval** you must submit the completed Ethical Application Form online. A copy of the form is provided on Moodle as a guide. For further instructions about the form and the online submission process please contact the School's Research Ethics Lead Dr Swati Chandna via email to: s.chandna@bbk.ac.uk and cs-ethics@bbk.ac.uk

Ethics, risks and mitigation strategies

What is **risk assessment** for your project?

- For example, if you have open research questions, or you are not sure the data are available or in a format that can be directly used for machine learning or statistical analysis, “fallback” plans should be laid out; e.g. you can provide a risk analysis plan and risk mitigation strategies.
- Explain risk impact score for each of the risks you have identified and order them to identify the critical risks to your project.

Marking criteria for proposal

- The proposal and the report are marked by independent markers and moderated by the supervisor.
- Their comments are made available via Moodle's Turnitin Feedback Studio.
- In the event of disagreement between the supervisor and the marker (marks differ more than 5%) a third marker will also assess the project.
- External Examiners are given access to review all projects, although in practice each External reviews only a sample. However, they routinely review marginal cases or projects with strong disagreement between markers (e.g. three markers disagree, or marks are in different grade categories).

Marking criteria for proposal (see “Key information” tile on Moodle)

- Background research (includes literature review)- **35/100**
- Presentation of the problem (includes aims and objectives)- **15/100**
- Plan for developing the solution (includes methodology, methods, workplan, risks, ethics)- **30/100**
- Presentation of the proposal (includes references, polished language, use of appropriate tables/figures etc)- **20/100**
  - **Exceeding the word limits results in a 10-mark penalty for Presentation., i.e. max mark is 10/100 for Presentation.**

Using and referring to existing material/sources and assessment offences

The following are all examples of assessment offences:

- Plagiarism - the presentation of another person's thoughts or words or artefacts or other output in such a way that they could be assumed to be your own.
- Collusion - producing a piece of work for formal assessment with the assistance of another person, or persons, when the assignment was to have been undertaken and completed by you working individually.
- Contract Cheating - where a student submits work for assessment in part or in entirety where they have used one or more of a range of services provided by a third party, such as an essay mill, which is not permitted. Please be aware that services like Chegg are willing to cooperate with the School on contact cheating – in examinations they have provided us details of the question submitters and full answers published.

Assessment offences

- Use of text generated from AI tools, such as ChatGPT etc– any use of AI should be acknowledged in your text by providing in-text citation, and the prompts that were used in an appendix.
- The use of prompts that are intended to circumvent AI detection- e.g. requesting the paraphrasing of material to evade such detection or to simulate authorship by a less experienced student- may be taken as academic misconduct, as they indicate a deliberate awareness of dishonest practice.
- Replicating AI-generated text, particularly in a verbatim manner, reflects inadequate poor engagement with and assimilation of the material/concepts, which may consequently lead to lower marks.
- Turnitin scans and assesses all submissions for evidence of AI tool usage.
- If your references include sources identified with the use of AI tools, then it is good practice to review the results carefully as these tools can generate inaccurate or misleading information and even "hallucinate" nonexistent sources or facts. A good starting point is to verify that there are no fabricated data, e.g. verify authors and title, research purpose of article is stated correctly, study design or experiments described correctly, terminology is used properly, theoretical, conceptual and/or methodological issues are framed appropriately, and they are not misrepresented, significant issues are not omitted.

Plagiarism

- The College's Policy on Assessment Offences lists examples (http://www.bbk.ac.uk/reg/regs/) and penalties

- ***The Avoiding Plagiarism module on Moodle:*** you can self-enroll https://moodle.bbk.ac.uk/enrol/index.php?id=45

Using Existing Material

- However, nobody expects you to reinvent the wheel
- You are allowed to use existing work as a basis for your project, provided that:
  - you reference this work properly
  - there is enough of your own work in the project
  - you don’t have a collage of other people’s work
- You should not quote large chunks of text from another source! **Excessive quotation indicates that you're not thinking enough for yourself, and markers may consider it a poor substitute for critical analysis. Doing so may reduce the marks awarded in certain criteria.**
  - The simplest thing would be to summarise it in your own words and reference the source.
  - The ideal thing is of course to provide a critical analysis of other people’s work, identify gaps and provide insights that can inform the work in your project or can help you justifying decisions taken about your own project.

References

- References include the full bibliographic information about the source, such as the author(s)'s name(s), date of publication, title of work, place of publication, and publisher. This information is usually given in the section called References or Bibliography at the end of the text. The key principle is that you should give enough information to allow another person to find the source for themselves.

- Here are some examples using the Harvard referencing system:
- [when you are referring to a book]

Lewin, K., 1951. Field Theory in Social Science. New York: Harper and Row.

- [when you are referring to a chapter in a book, where 'ed.' means editor, and 'edn.' means 'edition']

Piaget, J., 1970. Piaget's theory. In: P. Smith, ed., Handbook of child psychology. 3rd edn. New York: Wiley, 1970, pp. 34-76.

References

- [when you are referring to a journal article]

Holmqvist, M., 2003. A Dynamic Model of Intra- and Interorganizational Learning. Organization Studies, 24(1), 95-123.

- [when you are referring to a webpage]

W3C, Web Accessibility Guidelines and Techniques, available online at http://www.w3.org/WAI/guid-tech.html. Last accessed 12/02/2023.

- Independent of their type (e.g. book, article, webpage), all references are included at the end of your document in alphabetical order starting from the author's name as in the example above.

- Harvard guide to citing references. Available to online at: https://www.slideshare.net/leshere/harvard-citation-hlp

References

- All references should be cited in the body of the text. A typical reference might take the form, “Donar and Kebab (1996) suggest that high cholesterol levels do not lead to heart disease....” or “empirical eating studies show that.... (Donar and Kebab, 1996)”.

- You can add Bibliography, a list any relevant literature that has not been cited in the report and does not appear in the References.

- **You should use the Harvard Referencing system**

Final piece of advice

- All figures and tables must be properly explained in the text
- Make sure that you have an adequate Workplan
  - Have a list of workpackages describing what you plan to do in the project
  - Make sure that you provide time estimates/timescale for each workpackage and list the activities within each workpackage
  - Provide time estimates for each task/activity in each workpackage, if you can.
- Avoid using buzzwords
  - Avoid generic text that sounds good but does not add extra information (this gives a bad impression, far worse than being slightly less than the word count).
  - Avoid use of textbook material – that’s not useful in an MSc project.
- Cohesion
  - Try to have a well organised work, easy to follow and logically coherent- align workpackages with project objectives.

Final piece of advice

- **Familiarise yourselves with the project** module guidance/briefings, the pass criteria and the submission requirements before undertaking any assessments or reassessments (“Key Information” tile)
- **You receive feedback on your work/drafts from your supervisor, and you should maintain contact with them throughout the duration of the module.**
- **Write the proposal, not for your supervisor, but as if you are addressing the Independent Marker or the External Examiner**:
  - someone you do not know and who knows nothing about your project.
  - Do not assume that the reader already knows about your project.
- In Sciences, academic writing normally focuses on a clear topic, sound objectives, and paints the author as a source of authority. First-person pronouns like “you” and “I” pull the focus away from the topic and shift it to the author and make the work seem less objective- the opposite of your goal.

Final piece of advice

Use of GenAI tools: for the purposes of module assessments (including proposals and reports- see Moodle), the use of AI or AI-assisted technologies in the execution of substantive project tasks- such as the generation of scientific insights, the identification of research gaps, systems and interaction design, methodology and methods design, data analysis and interpretation, or the formulation of scientific hypotheses, project objectives or conclusions- is prohibited. These are core learning tasks that must be completed by the student. Using AI in these areas, especially if it involves relying on false or invented references in the literature review or in supporting research, methodology, methods or design decisions, is strictly not allowed.

Word limits: confirm that your proposal complies with the word limit- include word count in the cover page.

Final piece of advice

Check the deadlines on Moodle:

MSc - https://moodle.bbk.ac.uk/course/view.php?id=46927

PGCert - https://moodle.bbk.ac.uk/course/view.php?id=46658

- There is a normal deadline and a cut-off deadline (submit until the cut-off but the usual College penalties apply)
- If you miss the cut-off deadline, you won't be able to submit your proposal.
- To avoid the penalty, you must claim mitigating circumstances and provide evidence to support your claims. Please contact admin directly for advice.
- According to the regulation, lecturers do not approve extensions, deferrals, late submissions or mitigating circumstances claims and they are not involved in the approval process in any way.
- Classic reference: Kathleen McMillan and Jonathan Weyers, *How to Write Essays & Assignment*

The next briefing is about the Project report

- That’s a deliverable that presents the problem area, the aims and objectives of the project, the relevant work, the methodology, and the proposed solution.
- It counts 80% of the project mark
- There are strict requirements and word limit. If you'd like to explore further, details are available on Moodle:
  - PGCert
  - MSc
- **The third briefing (10th of July 2026, 7:00pm on Teams) is dedicated to the report**

Questions?